Tim Leffler

Munich Graduate School of Economics

Primary field: Applied Microeconomics
Secondary fields: Political Economy, Behavioral Economics
Research topics: Human Capital, Inequality, Digital Skills, Political Behavior, NLP, Multimodal Data

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REFERENCES

Prof. Dr. Florian Englmaier
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Prof. Dr. Fabian Kosse
University of Würzburg
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EDUCATION

Expected March 2027	**PhD in Economics**	LMU Munich
Sept.–Nov. 2026	**Research Visit**, Elliott Ash's AI & Economics Lab	ETH Zurich
June 2024	**Research Visit**, Nicola Lacetera	University of Toronto
March–May 2024	**Research Visit**, John List's research group	University of Chicago
2017–2020	**MSc Economics**	University of Bonn
2013–2017	**BSc Economics**	University of Bonn
2015–2016	**Study Abroad** (PROMOS Scholarship)	National Chengchi University, Taiwan

Funding: Jacobs Foundation Scholarship (Sept. 2020–Aug. 2021); CRC TRR 190 research visits (2024).

JOB MARKET PAPER

Facing the Far Right, or Looking Away? Video Evidence from Parliament latest version

Confronting a far-right party can lend it standing; ignoring it leaves its claims unanswered. We study how established legislators allocate public attention to a far-right challenger once they must work alongside it. From more than 23,000 German Bundestag speeches with video, audio, and text aligned word by word, we measure engagement with the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) after its 2017 entry: whether a speech names the party, and whether the speaker turns toward its benches. Identification comes from an indivisibility in the rule that allocates committee seats, which varies how many AfD colleagues a legislator works with, across 9,376 speeches by 269 legislators who kept a committee through the 2017 election. Across the full range of exposure, engagement falls by 0.41 standard deviations; the probability that a speech names the AfD falls from 35 to 24 percent, about 8.5 percentage points per additional AfD colleague on a committee of average size. The decline is concentrated in negatively worded mentions, and naming of the established parties does not move. Working alongside the challenger reduces the public attention established legislators direct at it.

OTHER WORKING PAPERS

Digital Skills: Social Disparities and the Impact of Early Mentoring

with Fabian Kosse and Arna Woemmel; CESifo Working Paper No. 11570

We investigate social disparities in digital skills, focusing on both actual proficiency levels and confidence in these skills. Drawing on a representative sample from Germany, we first demonstrate that both dimensions strongly predict labor market success. We then use this sample to identify gender and socioeconomic disparities in levels and confidence. Finally, using a long-run RCT panel framework with young adults, we confirm these disparities and provide causal evidence on the effects of enhancing the social environment in childhood. Assigning elementary school-aged children to a mentoring program persistently reduces socioeconomic gaps in confidence related to digital skills, but it does not affect the level of digital skills.

Accommodation of Right-Wing Populist Rhetoric: Evidence from Parliamentary Speeches in Germany

with Emilio Esguerra, Felix Hagemeister, and Julian Heid; CRC TRR 190 Discussion Paper No. 435

We provide novel evidence on how right-wing (populist) rhetoric spreads. Using several thousand speeches from the German parliament, we show that exposure to politicians from the right-wing populist Alternative for Germany (AfD) leads mainstream politicians to adopt a more distinctively right-wing populist language. We measure similarity to right-wing populist rhetoric via cosine similarity to both parliamentary speeches by the AfD and extremist speeches at far-right rallies, as well as using a populist dictionary method. To induce individual-level variation in exposure to AfD politicians, we exploit a quasi-exogenous allocation rule for committee members in the German parliament. Comparing a politician with the highest to one with the lowest relative AfD exposure increases the cosine similarity to right-wing populist speech by 0.1 of a standard deviation. Our results seem specific to right-wing populism and suggest strategic motives related to local electoral competition behind rhetorical changes among individual politicians.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Who Looks Up to Whom? Role Model Selection Amongst Teenagers: News Coverage Paired with Natural Language Processing

with Fabian Kosse

How do adolescents choose public-figure role models, and how does their social environment shape this choice? We link longitudinal survey data on teenagers and their families to a multilingual corpus of more than 200,000 news articles about the public figures they name. Using natural language processing, we construct detailed role-model profiles that capture demographics, occupations, and coverage of socially relevant behaviors and experiences. We use these data to study how adolescents' characteristics and socioeconomic backgrounds relate to the role models they select, and leverage a randomized childhood mentoring intervention to examine whether an enriched social environment changes subsequent role-model choice. The project connects the formation of aspirations to social learning and inequality while introducing a scalable approach for measuring the attributes of self-selected role models.

PRESENTATIONS

2026	Verein für Socialpolitik Annual Conference	Innsbruck
2024	Research visit and presentation	University of Chicago
2023	Economics Brownbag Seminar (invited)	University of Würzburg
2023	5th Annual COMPTEXT Conference	Glasgow
2023	Studi-BUCH Interdisciplinary Text-as-Data Workshop	Essen
2023	NextGenerationEconomics Spring Workshop	Hohenheim/Mannheim
2023	12th CRC Rationality and Competition Retreat	Berlin
2022	CRC Rationality and Competition Young Economist Workshop	Tutzing
2022	HCEO-briq Summer School on Socioeconomic Inequality	Bonn (poster)

ACADEMIC SERVICE

2026	Ad hoc referee, *Management Science*
2023–2024	Organizer, Interdisciplinary Workshop on Text and Unstructured Data, LMU Munich (three sessions)

TEACHING AND SUPERVISION

Summer 2026	Data Science in Business and Economics (Undergraduate)	Tutorial
2024–2027	Empirical and Experimental Behavioral Economics (Undergraduate)	Seminar
2024–2027	Policy and Management Evaluation Methods (Graduate)	Tutorial
2023–2024	Research Projects in Empirical Economic Research (Undergraduate)	Seminar
2023–2024	Introduction to Macroeconomics (Undergraduate)	Tutorial
2020–2026	Supervision of 28 theses	

RESEARCH AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2024–present	**Research Associate**, Chair of Data Science in Business and Economics	University of Würzburg
2024–present	**Junior Researcher**	C-BEAM
2021–2024	**Research Affiliate**	CRC TRR 190 Rationality and Competition
Jan.–May 2024	**Research Assistant**	IZA Institute of Labor Economics
2020–2023	**Research Assistant**	briq Institute on Behavior and Inequality
2017–2020	**Student Research Assistant**	briq Institute on Behavior and Inequality

LANGUAGES

German (native), English (very good), Mandarin Chinese (good), Spanish (basic), French (basic)

Last updated: October 2026